16
Stand-off in Siachen

Siachen figured prominently in the last decade of my military career, more so when I was the ADGMO at the Army HQ and thereafter. As many people are not well acquainted with the genesis of the Siachen problem between India and Pakistan, I have endeavoured here to cover its essentials.

Dividing the northernmost crown of India and originating from the mighty Karakoram range is the Siachen, the second-longest glacier in the world. As one flies northwards from the base camp along the 76.4-kilometre-long glacier, one is dazed by the awesome beauty of the sea of ice and snow with moraines on both sides right up to the horizon. It is a surreal sight as the panoramic view of Sia Kangri, Indira Col and the other craggy and rocky peaks and pinnacles on both sides of the glacier slowly emerge from the white haze (Panorama 16.1). There is a famous saying attributed to the people of the region: 'The land is so barren and the passes so high that only the best of friends and the fiercest of enemies come by.' On the west of the Siachen is the rugged Saltoro range, which forms the watershed between Baltistan and Nubra valley of Ladakh region. Siachen in the Balti language means 'the place which has abundance of roses'. It is the source of the Nubra river that goes on to join the Shyok river, which has its origin in the area of the Karakoram Pass. The Shyok drains into the Indus near Skardu.

At the end of hostilities in the Indo-Pak war of 1947–48, a ceasefire line in J&K was agreed to by both countries and was authenticated on the maps. This delineation was specific up to a point – NJ 9842 – and beyond that the agreement went on to say, *'and thence north to the glaciers'*. This position was maintained even